Student Level 150

Reading Comprehension Intervention Passages

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Allison

Allison and her friends couldn't wait to ride the gigantic ferris wheel called The Sky Scraper. As Allison's dad drove them to the amusement park, they couldn't stop talking about excited they were. Even the gray skies couldn't dampen their excitement.

When they arrived, they ran straight to The Sky Scraper where they were disappointed to see a long line. Allison and her friends decided to wait. After all, The Sky Scraper was what they had come for. So they waited. And waited. And waited. When it seemed like hours had passed, but was really only thirty minutes, it was their turn to climb onto The Sky Scraper. Allison and her friends squealed a little as the ride suddenly jolted upward.

The first round on the ferris wheel was amazing. As it carried the girls to the top, they could see for miles. They could see the farmland surrounding the park and from the very top they could see tiny little cows in the fields. A strong wind blew their hair all around their faces. As the wheel carried them down from the top, they felt their stomachs do flips and hoped they weren't going to embarrass themselves.

It was on the next round that the fun came to an end. As the wheel climbed up again, the girls felt it slowing down and heard a loud banging noise. As they reached the top, the wheel came to a sudden stop. A loudspeaker told the riders not to worry, that the ride would be fixed in a moment. Allison and her friends were nervous but stayed calm. At least until they realized what the gray skies and wind meant.

When Allison's dad came back to pick the girls up they were still damp. But they had a great story to tell!

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Questions for Allison

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What were Allison and her friends excited about?

2. Why were they disappointed when they got to The Sky Scraper?

3. Why did it seem like hours that the girls waited, when it was really only minutes?

4. What made Allison and her friends squeal?

5. What could they see as the ride lifted them upward?

6. Why were they afraid of embarrassing themselves on the way down?

7. What did the girls probably think was happening when they felt the wheel slowing down and heard the banging?

8. Why didn't the girls panic when the ride stopped suddenly?

9. What happened while the girls were still stuck on the ride?

10. How do you know they got rained on?

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Becky

Becky was a girl who liked puzzles. She liked jigsaw puzzles and word puzzles. She was very good at solving puzzles, even the kind that weren't in books or had pieces that fit together neatly. In fact, when Becky's mom lost her keys one day, it was Becky who solved the puzzle of where they were.

That morning, Becky's mom had made the grocery list but there were chores to be done before they could go to the store. Becky and her mom went upstairs to make the beds. Just then Becky's little brother woke up from his morning nap. Becky kept working in her room while her mom got her little brother up.

Soon all three were ready to go to the grocery store. The baby was in his car seat and everyone had their coats on. Just before they walked out the door though, Becky's mom realized she didn't have her keys. She knew that she'd had them that morning and that they must be in the house somewhere. She checked her coat pockets and purse. No keys. Knowing how good Becky was at solving puzzles, her mom asked her to help find them.

Becky thought back over the morning. She was pretty sure her mom had the keys when they were upstairs. Becky first looked in her mom's bedroom to see if she had dropped them there. No keys. Then she checked the baby's room. No keys on the floor or dresser but Becky was sure they must be upstairs somewhere. Suddenly she remembered hearing the jangle of keys when her mom was in her brother's room. She looked behind the changing table and there they were! They had fallen while her mom was changing him and that was the jangle she'd heard. Becky's mom was thrilled and bought Becky a special treat at the grocery store.

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Questions for Becky

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Becky good at?

2. What kinds of puzzles don't come in books or have pieces that fit together?

3. What did Becky and her mom do before going to the store?

4. Why is it important to the story that Becky stayed in her room while her mom got her brother up?

5. When did Becky's mom realize that she didn't have her keys?

6. Why did Becky's mom think that Becky would be able to find the keys?

7. Where did Becky check first for the keys?

8. Why does remembering the sound of the keys jangling help Becky?

9. Where did Becky find the keys?

10. Why did Becky's mom buy her a special treat?

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Bella and Duke

Bella had a dog named Duke whom she loved very much. Bella loved to lie on the floor in a patch of sun and read a book and Duke loved to lie down right next to her. Duke was an old dog and he napped while Bella read her book. For a while, both Bella and Duke were very happy.

As time went on, Bella was less happy to let Duke lie down next to her. The problem was his breath. As he got older, his breath got more and more stinky and eventually Bella did not want to lie so close to Duke. She started to read on the couch where Duke wasn't allowed. Duke looked at her with sad eyes.

Bella parents asked Bella why she didn't want to lie down with Duke anymore so she explained about his breath. Bella's parents were relieved and said that they could help. First they brought Duke some special chew treats. They were supposed to clean his teeth while he chewed them. Duke liked his new treats but they didn't help make his breath any better.

Bella's parents decided that Duke should get his teeth cleaned by the animal doctor. Duke's doctor agreed that Duke's teeth were very dirty and causing his bad breath. He used a special tool to get Duke's teeth nice and clean. He gave Bella a doggie toothbrush to take home. The doctor told Bella to brush Duke's teeth every day. Bella was nervous about using the brush on Duke's teeth, but Duke was so happy that Bella wanted to be with him, that he didn't mind one bit. Soon the two were back on the floor almost nose to nose.

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Questions for Bella and Duke

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Bella's dog named?

2. Why were Bella and Duke so happy to lie together in the sun?

3. Why did Bella stop like being so close to Duke?

4. Why did Duke look at Bella with sad eyes?

5. Why did Bella's parents feel relieved when Bella explained about Duke's breath?

6. What did they do first to try to make Duke's breath better?

7. How do you think Bella reacted when the chews didn't work?

8. What did Bella's parents do next?

9. What did the animal doctor tell Bella to do with Duke at home?

10. Why was Bella nervous about using the doggie toothbrush?

11. How do you know that the toothbrush worked?

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Bethany and Clara

Bethany and Clara were cousins who barely knew each other. Their lives couldn't be more different. Bethany lived near a big city where she could easily do things like hang out at the mall with friends. Clara lived on a farm and spent most of her free time helping with chores, which she enjoyed. The few times that the cousins had gotten together hadn't gone well. Bethany thought Clara was boring and Clara thought Bethany was stuck up. They were about to get to know each other much better, however.

Bethany's parents wanted her to do more than go to the mall. Clara's parents wanted Clara to have an idea of what life was like away from the farm. They came up with a plan to get the cousins together for summer break on the farm. Needless to say, there was a lot of unhappiness in both homes.

The whole way to the farm, Bethany sobbed as if her life was over. When they arrived, Clara smirked at Bethany's fancy boots and said she had an old pair that Bethany could use. When Bethany saw them her heart sank. Her friends would laugh out loud if they could see her in those boots! Each girl dreaded the coming summer for their own reasons.

As the summer went on, the cousins began to appreciate each other. Bethany grew to love the animals, particularly the chickens. It became her job to feed them every day and she loved the way they crowded around her. Clara was inspired by Bethany to get some fancy boots to wear in town instead of the old ones she always wore. At the end of the summer, the girls hugged each other tight and promised to spend as much time together as they could.

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Questions for Bethany and Clara

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Where did Bethany and Clara live?

2. Why wouldn't the cousins enjoy spending time together?

3. What do the parents decide to do to help them learn to like each other more?

4. Why would they do that?

5. How did Bethany behave on the trip to the farm?

6. Why did Clara smirk when she saw Bethany's boots?

7. Why did Bethany's heart sink when she saw the old boots?

8. What reasons did each girl have for dreading the summer?

9. What chore did Bethany learn to love?

10. What did the cousins learn from each other that summer?

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Carla

Carla had a gift for writing and singing songs. Her family and friends praised her talents and Carla loved to perform for them. That's why it was strange when Carla wasn't excited about a songwriting contest announced by a local radio station. They couldn't understand why she would hesitate even one minute to sign up. Carla thought she had a very good reason, however.

The contest rules clearly stated that the songwriter must perform his or her song for the judges. Even though Carla had performed many times for family and close friends, she had never sung her songs for anyone else. She was terrified at the idea of singing in front of strangers. What if they didn't think she was any good? Rather than take a chance, she decided not to enter the contest.

Carla's sister June and her best friend Lori were disappointed by Carla's decision. They were sure she could win the contest if she could only get over her stage fright. They came up with a plan to help Carla. They gathered just a few of Carla's good friends and asked Carla to sing for them after school. She didn't mind because they were all friends. Every day after that, they asked Carla to sing and invited others to listen. Soon Carla realized that she was singing to as many strangers as friends. Everyone who heard her encouraged her to enter the contest.

By the time the day of the contest arrived, Carla felt well prepared and was actually excited to sing for the judges. She had brought two of her biggest fans with her and as her name was called to perform, Carla sent a grateful look toward June and Lori.

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Questions for Carla

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Carla gifted in?

2. Why did Carla's family think it was strange that Carla didn't want to enter the songwriting contest?

3. What was the reason that Carla didn't want to enter the contest?

4. What was Carla afraid of?

5. Who was upset about Carla's decision not to enter the contest?

6. Why did they decide to help Carla get over her stage fright?

7. What plan did June and Lori come up with?

8. Why did they think this plan would help Carla?

9. Did June and Lori's plan work?

10. Why did Carla send a grateful look at June and Lori?

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Charlie and Chris

Charlie and Chris were goofing around in the park and getting bored when they suddenly heard shouting. Looking up, they saw a big dog running straight towards them. Behind the dog was an elderly man shouting Rex and struggling to catch up. Charlie and Chris nodded at each other and took off running after Rex.

The dog was fast but so were Charlie and Chris. Then Rex put on a burst of speed. Did he think they were playing a game? Just then Charlie realized that the dog was headed straight for a group having a picnic on the grass. Without even pausing, Rex took a gigantic leap right over the blanket and through the middle of the group. Noticing their wide eyes and open mouths, Charlie and Chris ran around them.

Rex led the boys on several more adventures. At one point, he ran through some sprinklers. Charlie and Chris slipped and slid on the wet grass but managed to continue the chase. Nearing the concert pavilion, a policeman saw the dog and children running at top speed. He quickly realized what was happening and blew his whistle. It was amazing! Everyone stopped in their tracks. For about two seconds. Then Rex took off again with Charlie and Chris right behind him.

By now everyone was slowing down, even Rex. Charlie realized they were back at the point where they had first seen the old man. In fact, there he was sitting on a bench. Surprisingly, Rex ran right up to the old man and sat down next to him. Charlie and Chris collapsed on the bench. When they could talk, they described their adventures. Rex's owner was so appreciative of the help that he bought them treats from the ice cream truck. It turned out to be quite an exciting day in the park after all.

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Questions for Charlie and Chris

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Charlie and Chris see running towards them in the park?

2. Why did Charlie and Chris both start running after Rex without even saying anything?

3. What was the first obstacle Rex and the boys encountered?

4. With their wide eyes and open mouths, how did the group feel about Rex jumping over their picnic?

5. Where did Rex lead the boys next?

6. Why did everyone stop when the policeman blew his whistle?

7. Why did they only stop for about two seconds?

8. Where did Rex end up leading them?

9. Why was it a surprise that Rex went and sat down with his owner?

10. How did Rex's owner thank the boys?

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D'Andre

D'Andre wanted to surprise his mom with something special for Mother's Day. He knew that she had become interested in fairy gardens recently and decided to make her one. He wasn't exactly sure what a fairy garden was so he got his dad involved. His dad wasn't sure either, so together they went to the garden center.

At the garden center, D'Andre told an employee what he wanted to do. The employee, who's name was Sam, was happy to help. Sam loved to get youngsters interested in gardening. He believed that designing a fairy garden was a perfect way to get started. He walked D'Andre and his dad over to where examples of fairy gardens were displayed.

Sam explained the basics of a fairy garden. He said that it was like a regular garden, but in miniature, and pointed out one display that looked like a woodland garden. The plants were trimmed to look like tiny evergreen trees and bushes. There were small rocks that looked like boulders next to the tiny trees. Very small stones made a walking path through the garden, just like a regular size garden would have. There were even tiny little mushrooms growing in moss. The whole garden fit into a pot made to look like a tree stump. D'Andre and his dad looked at each other, smiled and told Sam they didn't need to see anything else.

Mother's Day was that weekend. After breakfast in bed, D'Andre told his mom that her gift was outside. She looked confused as he led her toward an area of the backyard covered with a blue tarp. Her confusion turned to joy when D'Andre and his father lifted the tarp to reveal a beautiful woodland fairy garden. D'Andre joked later that his cheek was sore from all his mom's kisses!

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Questions for D'Andre

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What holiday was D'Andre excited for?

2. Why did D'Andre ask his dad for help?

3. What was the employee's name at the garden center?

4. Why did Sam think that designing a fairy garden would help get children interested in gardening?

5. How is a fairy garden different from a regular garden?

6. How did the garden center use rocks and stones in the woodland fairy garden?

7. Why do you think D'Andre and his father were so excited about the woodland fairy garden?

8. Why did D'Andre's mom look confused when he led her into the back yard?

9. How did her mood change when D'Andre and his father lifted the tarp?

10. Do you think D'Andre's cheek was really sore from all his mom's kisses?

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Danny

The sky outside Danny's school was completely covered in black clouds and he could barely see the sun. Bad weather was coming and Danny knew that several of his classmates were afraid of storms. He wondered what he could do to help them stay calm.

Just then they heard the siren indicating that dangerous weather was nearby. Immediately, some of Danny's classmates began to cry out. Their teacher reminded everyone that they had practiced for this and said not to panic. The first step was to get into one line. Danny helped his friends get into an orderly line. He whispered to those who seemed particularly frightened that they would be safe. As the line of students left the classroom, Danny went to the back to make sure that no one was left behind.

Their teacher led the class down the steps to the basement. Danny, at the end of the line was proud of his classmates for being so calm and orderly. As the group reached the bottom of the steps however, the noise from all the other classes got loud. Danny could see that some of his classmates were getting nervous again. When they reached their spot in the basement, Danny sat with those friends he knew were particularly frightened. He worked hard to distract them from the booms of thunder outside. He quietly told funny stories and jokes. Soon everyone had settled down and were calmly listening to Danny.

Luckily the storm passed quickly and before long the class was back in their classroom. Danny's friends and teacher were impressed with his calm leadership. His teacher actually created a classroom title for Danny. He was officially known as the Storm Whisperer from then on.

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Questions for Danny

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Danny see outside his classroom window?

2. Why did Danny want to help his friends stay calm?

3. How did Danny and his class know the storm was getting close?

4. Why did Danny whisper to his classmates that they would be safe?

5. Why was Danny proud of the way his classmates behaved on the way to the basement?

6. What happened to make the students in Danny's class feel nervous again?

7. Why did Danny tell funny stories and jokes to distract his friends?

8. Did telling funny stories and jokes work to keep everyone calm?

9. Once the storm was over, did Danny's classmates appreciate his help?

10. Why did Danny's teacher give him a special classroom title?

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Eddie

Eddie had gotten a telescope for his birthday. He thought he was the luckiest kid on the planet. Eddie's father knew a great deal about stars and had been teaching Eddie about them ever since he was little. They loved to go camping far away from the city lights and watch the stars at night. Eddie and his father even had a special calendar that told them what would be happening in the sky on any night. In school, Eddie talked constantly about stars. His friends teasingly called him a nerd.

Eddie loved using his telescope and he wanted to share that joy with his friends. Talking about stars didn't get them interested so he decided to invite them to look through the telescope themselves. He looked at his star calendar and chose a night that would be particularly good for star watching. He told them to meet in his backyard after dark.

Eddie waited impatiently for the sun to go down that night. He and his father got the telescope set up so that it was pointing in the right direction to see the most stars. He asked his mom to make cocoa and her famous chocolate chip cookies. Finally his friends arrived. Eddie gave a little speech about what they would see that night. His friends looked at each other and rolled their eyes but they were beginning to catch his enthusiasm. As they took turns looking through the telescope into the night sky, Eddie's friends finally understood what he was talking about. The stars were amazing!

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Questions for Eddie

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Eddie get for his birthday?

2. Why did Eddie and his father leave the city to go camping?

3. What did Eddie and his father use to tell them what the stars would be like on any night?

4. What did Eddie's friends think of Eddie?

5. What did Eddie decide to do to get his friends interested in stars?

6. Why did he use his star calendar to help pick a night to invite his friends over?

7. On the night that his friends were coming over, what did Eddie and his father do with the telescope?

8. Why would Eddie ask his mom to make cocoa and cookies?

9. What did Eddie do that made his friends roll their eyes?

10. Why did the friends start to catch Eddie's enthusiasm?

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Fred

Fred was really excited. His birthday was coming up and he was pretty sure that his parents were going to give him a new bike. He had left clues for them all over the house indicating exactly which bike he wanted. He'd "accidentally" left pictures of the bike on the kitchen counter where his mom would see them. He'd also "casually" mentioned the bike in several conversations with his dad. Fred didn't think there was any way that his parents couldn't know exactly what he wanted for his birthday.

On his birthday, Fred jumped out of bed and got dressed quickly. His parents greeted him with cries of Happy Birthday! Fred could see a few brightly wrapped packages on the table. Nothing big enough to hold a bike, however. Before breakfast, he took a quick look around the house and even ran out to the garage. No bikes anywhere. Head hanging low, Fred sat down to breakfast. His parents smiled at each other over Fred's head.

After breakfast Fred opened his presents. Some video games from his parents and pajamas from his grandparents. Fred rolled his eyes when he opened the pajamas. Apparently, his grandparents still thought he was in first grade! Fred sighed and said he was going to play the new video games. His mom said there was one more gift and his dad got a box from the closet. Fred could see it wasn't a bike so he wasn't too excited about opening it. When he finally did get the wrapping paper off, it turned out to be a new bike helmet. Surprised, Fred looked up at his parents who both had big smiles. Just then the doorbell rang. Fred ran to open the door and there were his grandparents holding a bike. The exact bike Fred had wanted! Fred made sure to give everyone extra special hugs that day.

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Questions for Fred

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Fred hope to get for his birthday?

2. Why did Fred leave clues around the house about the bike instead of just asking for it?

3. What did Fred do before breakfast on his birthday?

4. When Fred sat down to breakfast his head was hanging low. How do you think he was feeling?

5. What presents did Fred open after breakfast?

6. Why did Fred roll his eyes when he opened the pajamas?

7. What did Fred's mom tell him before he went to play video games?

8. Why was Fred surprised when he unwrapped the bike helmet?

9. When Fred opened the door what did he see?

10. Why did Fred give everyone extra special hugs that day?

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Jill

Jill was one of the best soccer players on her team. Part of the reason that she was so good was that she was not afraid to make difficult plays. Time after time, Jill would run at the ball without stopping to think that she might get hurt. Jill's coach and her parents all asked Jill to be more careful. They worried that she cared too much about winning and not enough about safety.

One day, Jill's parents' fears became a reality. As she raced toward the ball, she didn't see that a member of the other team was also racing for the ball. The two players collided and Jill landed hard on her left arm. She immediately felt a sharp, stabbing pain where her wrist and arm came together and began sobbing. As her parents rushed onto the field they both wondered if she would finally understand their concerns.

At the hospital, the doctor asked Jill to wiggle her fingers. Jill could, but it hurt. He told Jill and her parents that he thought her wrist was broken and that he was going to take an x-ray to be certain. Sure enough, Jill's wrist was broken. When they finally left the hospital that day, Jill's left arm was covered with a solid cast which she would have to wear for four weeks. Right-handed, Jill was disappointed that it was her left arm in a cast.

The next four weeks went slowly for Jill. Even though her friends all signed her cast, she couldn't play soccer and her arm was quite sore. Jill's parents and coach talked to her about how soccer should be more about having fun than winning. Now that she knew what an injury felt like, Jill agreed.

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Questions for Jill

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What sport did Jill play?

2. Why did Jill's parents and coach worry that she was too interested in winning?

3. How did Jill break her wrist?

4. Why did Jill's parents think that she might finally understand their concerns?

5. At the hospital, what did the doctor do to decide that Jill's wrist was broken?

6. Why do you think Jill was disappointed that it was her left arm in a cast?

7. Did Jill enjoy having her arm in a cast for four weeks?

8. Was there anything good about having her arm in a cast?

9. What did Jill's parents and coach talk to her about?

10. Why did Jill finally understand and agree with them?

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Jordan

Jordan and his family had a tradition of eating pizza at DeLuca's on Friday nights. It began when his mother put her foot down one Friday saying she just couldn't cook one more meal that week! Because they went every week, Jordan's family got to know the staff at DeLuca's and the staff looked forward to seeing Jordan and his family on Fridays.

Jordan's favorite waiter was Max. Max was quite a character. He greeted everyone by name and always had new knock-knock jokes to share with Jordan. He acted clumsy when he carried drinks or trays. Sometimes he pretended to almost drop drinks or pizzas into customers' laps. But he always stopped himself just before a catastrophe. Everyone laughed and clapped at Max's antics. He beamed at his audience and bowed.

One Friday, when Jordan's family arrived at DeLuca's, they could tell that something was different. The customers were quieter than usual and the staff hurried to fill orders without their usual enthusiasm. Jordan looked around the restaurant for Max. He had some jokes he wanted to share with Max this week. But Max was nowhere to be seen. Another waiter, Ben, came to take their order. Jordan asked where Max was and Ben said that Max had tripped in the kitchen and broken his arm. He wouldn't be able to come back to work for several weeks.

Jordan and his family were sad. They loved seeing Max each week. They missed his company. Then Jordan had an idea and whispered a question to his parents. They smiled and nodded at Jordan and suggested he talk to the manager. The next Friday, Jordan and his family had a special guest at their table Max! Everyone in the restaurant was pleased to see Max and wished him a speedy recovery.

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Questions for Jordan

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What is Jordan's family's tradition?

2. Was Jordan's mother being serious when she said that “she just couldn't cook one more meal that week”?

3. What was Jordan's favorite waiter named?

4. Why was Max so popular at the restaurant?

5. Did Max enjoy making the customers laugh?

6. What led Jordan and his family to believe something was wrong when they got to DeLuca's one Friday?

7. Why wasn't Max there that night?

8. Why was the restaurant quieter without Max?

9. What was the idea that Jordan whispered to his parents?

10. How did the customers react when they saw Max eating with Jordan's family?

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Kaleb

Kaleb had his first cavity. He knew this because his tooth had been aching for some time. He hadn't told his parents because he didn't want to go to the dentist. His friend Scott had told him that filling the cavity would hurt even worse than the achy tooth did. Scott described the needles and drills the dentist would use in great detail. Kaleb was in no hurry to experience that.

Finally, the ache got bad enough that Kaleb had to tell his parents, He also told them what Scott had said about how much it would hurt. Kaleb's parents reassured him that Scott was only teasing and that it wouldn't hurt at all. They said he'd be much happier after the cavity was filled and made an appointment for the next day.

Kaleb's mom took him to the dentist before school. All the way there, he tried to talk his mom out of going. He told her that the ache had gone away and that he felt fine. Kaleb's mom knew better and reminded him that everything would be all right. By the time they arrived at the dentist's office, Kaleb was only slightly less nervous.

The dentist and her assistants were their usual cheerful selves. They explained exactly what would happen. Immediately, he asked about the shots and how much they would hurt. The dentist chuckled and said that everyone was worried about the shots. She explained that they had special numbing medicine to put on his gums before the shots. She promised that he wouldn't feel any pain.

About an hour later, Kaleb was at school. His parents and the dentist had been right and he hadn't felt any pain. The funny thing was that no one could understand him when he tried to describe his trip to the dentist.

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Questions for Kaleb

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. How did Kaleb know he had a cavity?

2. How did Scott know what getting a cavity would filled would feel like?

3. What did Kaleb's parents say about what Scott had told Kaleb?

4. Why did they say that he would feel happier after the cavity was filled?

5. What did Kaleb do on the way to the dentist's office?

6. Why did Kaleb's mom take him anyway?

7. What was the first thing Kaleb asked the dentist about?

8. Why did the dentist chuckle when Kaleb asked about the shots?

9. What did the dentist say she would use so that the shots wouldn't hurt?

10. Why couldn't anyone understand Kaleb when he got back to school?

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Karen

Karen's grandmother had recently moved from her house to an apartment in a building that was for senior citizens. Karen's grandmother was happy she didn't have to climb stairs to get to her bedroom or do laundry anymore. She also loved the fact that the apartment building provided lots of activities for it's residents. As soon as she moved in, she sold her car.

Karen was disappointed that her grandmother sold her car. For as long as she could remember, she and her grandmother had a tradition of spending Friday afternoons and evenings together. After school, they went to a movie or a museum or the mall. Then they ate dinner at their favorite restaurant. It had a wall that was really a huge fish tank! Karen and her grandmother loved to watch the fish swim as they ate. Karen worried that the Friday tradition would be coming to an end.

After giving her grandmother a couple of weeks to settle into her new place, Karen went to see her one Friday. Her grandmother's new apartment was on the fifth floor. Karen had to agree that riding in the elevator was pretty cool. From the windows of the apartment, Karen could see all the way to the lake. It was nice but she wondered what they were going to do for the rest of the day without a car.

After a snack, Karen's grandmother took her back downstairs to show her the Activities Room. There were puzzles, joke books, DVD's, games and more. Karen's grandmother reassured her that they could make use of anything in the room. She also said that they could take a special bus to all their usual places. Including, she said with a wink, the fish tank restaurant! Smiling, Karen gave her grandmother a very big hug.

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Questions for Karen

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Where did Karen's grandmother move?

2. Why would Karen's grandmother be happy not to have to climb stairs anymore?

3. What did Karen's grandmother do with her car?

4. Why was Karen worried when she sold her car?

5. What did Karen like about her grandmother's apartment when she went for the first visit?

6. Even though it was nice, Karen was still concerned. Why?

7. Where did Karen's grandmother take her after their snack?

8. Why did Karen's grandmother want Karen to see the Activities Room?

9. Karen's grandmother told her that they could still do all their favorite things, even without a car. How?

10. Why do you think that Karen gave her grandmother a big hug?

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Keisha

Keisha's grandmother was moving from her home in another state and would be living at Keisha's house until she could find her own. Unfortunately, that meant Keisha had to give up her bedroom and move in with her sister Izzy. Keisha loved her grandmother and was excited that she would be living closer, but she was not excited about sharing with Izzy. Izzy was kind of a slob.

Keisha worked hard getting ready for her grandmother. She emptied her closet and dresser. She dusted every inch of her room and vacuumed the floor. It was sparkling when she finished. She was proud of her hard work and knew her grandmother would appreciate it. Then it was time to move her things into Izzy's room but as soon as she opened the door to Izzy's room, she felt discouraged and wondered how this could possibly work.

Izzy's room looked like a tornado had gone through. It was a complete disaster. Clothes were thrown on the floor and bed. There was even a shirt hanging from the ceiling fan. The beds weren't made and there were books and papers all over the bed Keisha was supposed to sleep in. It was obvious that Izzy hadn't vacuumed or dusted in some time. Keisha heaved a huge sigh.

Just then Izzy walked in. She could tell that Keisha was disappointed at the condition of her room. She suggested they work together to clean up. Right away Keisha felt better because Izzy had made the suggestion. The sisters spent several hours picking up Izzy's things and making room for Keisha's. While they worked, they talked and laughed and the project went faster than Keisha had expected. By the time Izzy's room was sparkling, both sisters were excited to be sharing it.

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Questions for Keisha

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Who was coming to stay with Keisha's family?

2. Why did it bother Keisha that her sister was a slob?

3. What did Keisha do to get her room ready for her grandmother?

4. Why did Keisha work so hard to get the room ready?

5. What did Keisha think Izzy's room looked like when she first saw it?

6. Why did Keisha sigh when she saw what Izzy's room looked like?

7. What was covering the bed that Keisha was supposed to sleep in?

8. Why did Keisha feel better when Izzy suggested they work together to clean up the room?

9. What made the time go fast while the sisters were busy cleaning Izzy's room?

10. Why did working together make both Keisha and Izzy excited to share the room?

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Lorna and Becky

Lorna and Becky were friends who had never met! They were pen pals who lived in different states. Lorna lived in Minnesota and Becky lived in Florida. Since the program was through their schools, they were required to report on the experience at the end of the year. Lorna and Becky would have to get to know each other really well!

Both girls were excited and wrote their first letters right away. It was winter and Lorna described the snow on the ground. She told Becky about the new winter boots she'd gotten with fur around the tops. And she told Becky about the skating unit coming up in gym class that she and her friends were looking forward to. Becky wrote to Lorna and told her about the huge thunderstorm they'd had the day before. She said that she was glad she'd had her rain boots. She told Lorna that her class was studying ocean migration and that they were going on a whale watch soon.

Lorna and Becky continued to write to each other through the school year. The more they wrote, the more they discovered similarities between them. For instance, both girls wore sunscreen every day, even though their weather was very different. They realized that they liked the same style of clothing and often wore similar outfits to school. Becky gently teased Lorna about having to cover her clothes up with a parka. Lorna teased Becky right back about having to be on the lookout for alligators everywhere.

When it came time to do their reports, each girl felt that she knew the other really well. Lorna was able to describe Becky's life in a tropical state and Becky was able to describe Lorna's life in a cold climate. Both girls received A's on their reports. More importantly, each made a new friend.

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Questions for Lorna and Becky

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. How did Lorna and Becky become friends?

2. Why did the girls have to get to know each other really well?

3. What kind of weather did Lorna and Becky write about?

4. Lorna and Becky's schools each took advantage of their particular weather. Why was that a good thing?

5. What did Lorna and Becky both wear on their feet?

6. Why do you think that Lorna and Becky kept writing to each other after the first letter?

7. Even though they lived in very different places, how did Lorna and Becky both protect their skin?

8. How might teasing each other help deepen their friendship?

9. How did Lorna and Becky do on their reports about each other?

10. Do you think that Lorna and Becky might want to meet each other one day?

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Pete

Pete had a problem. He and his grandfather had arranged to have breakfast together this Saturday then rake the leaves in his grandfather's yard. It was an annual tradition that Pete and his grandfather both looked forward to. The problem was that this year Pete had been invited to his friend Mike's birthday party on the same day. Mike was having a soccer party and most of their friends would be there. Pete was torn between wanting to be with his grandfather and wanting to go to Mike's party.

Pete's parents suggested he call his grandfather to see if they could do the raking another day. Unfortunately, his grandfather had cleared his schedule for that particular day. He wouldn't be available again for several weeks. Pete loved spending time with his grandfather and didn't want to wait that long to see him. He also knew that his grandfather counted on his help to rake the leaves. Pete decided he had made a commitment to his grandfather that he needed to keep. He said he'd be there for breakfast as usual.

Pete's grandfather could tell from Pete's voice on the phone that it had been a hard decision to make. He asked Pete if he would be willing to get up extra early to rake. They wouldn't be able to get breakfast at their favorite diner but they could definitely get the raking done before the party. Pete quickly agreed and even did a little happy dance.

Pete and his grandfather worked hard that morning and got all the leaves raked up. In fact, they worked so quickly that there was enough time to go out for lunch before the party. It turned out to be an absolutely perfect day. Pete was proud that he hadn't let anyone down, including himself.

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Questions for Pete

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Pete and his grandfather do together once every year?

2. Does Pete have a good relationship with his grandfather?

3. What is the problem that Pete has?

4. Why is this a problem for Pete?

5. What suggestion do Pete's parents make?

6. Pete decides to skip the party and help his grandfather instead. What kind of kid is Pete?

7. What does Pete's grandfather suggest?

8. Why does Pete do a happy dance?

9. Because they worked so hard and quickly, what were Pete and his grandfather able to do that they hadn't expected?

10. Why does Pete feel proud?

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Ryan

Ryan's parents thought he was old enough to help out around the house but when they told Ryan, he wasn't exactly excited. He liked his lazy lifestyle and didn't want to change anything. However, when his parents told him that, except for birthdays and other holidays, they would not buy him games, books or candy anymore, his attitude changed quickly. Especially when they told him that he would be paid for his help.

Ryan's parents put together a list of jobs they wanted him to do. First on the list was laundry. Ryan's parents thought he could help by carrying the baskets of laundry down to the basement where the machines were. Ryan had always hated their basement because of the spiders that lived there. He did not want to go down there for any reason. His parents sighed but told him that he could fold the clean clothes instead. Ryan was relieved.

Next on the list was the garbage. They wanted Ryan to take the garbage out to the alley every couple of days. Ryan hated the stinky garbage can in the alley and wanted nothing to do with it. Again, his parents sighed but told him he could take out the recycling instead. Ryan was pleased because the recycling didn't stink nearly as much.

So far this wasn't going as well as Ryan's parents had hoped. Ryan did not want to do the jobs they suggested for him so they decided to ask him what he wanted to do. Ryan thought for a bit then asked if there were any jobs he could do outside. This time Ryan's parents smiled at each other. The next day they went to the hardware store and bought Ryan his very own rake and shovel.

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Questions for Ryan

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What do Ryan's parents want him to do?

2. Why do you think Ryan likes his lazy lifestyle?

3. Why does his attitude change when his parents tell him they will only buy him things on his birthday or other holidays?

4. Why doesn't Ryan want to take the laundry down to the basement?

5. What solution do they decide on?

6. Next Ryan's parents suggest he take the garbage out but Ryan doesn't want to do that either. Why do you think Ryan's parents sighed when he told them he didn't want to do that job either?

7. What do they let Ryan do instead of taking out the garbage?

8. Since Ryan didn't like the jobs they suggested, what did they decide to do?

9. Why did Ryan's parents smile when he told them he liked being outside?

10. What do you think those chores were?

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Sammy and Matt

Sammy's class was taking a field trip to the natural history museum. Sammy was excited because he knew that the museum had a new T Rex exhibit. Every student was paired with a buddy and they had to spend the whole day together. Sammy groaned when he found out that his buddy was Matt. Matt didn't like dinosaurs and Sammy was worried that he wouldn't get to see the T Rex.

Sammy and Matt entered the museum together. At the opposite end of the museum, Sammy could see the dinosaur exhibit and started to walk toward it. Unfortunately, Matt could also see the dinosaur exhibit and he walked quickly toward a different area. Sammy knew he had to follow.

Sammy and Matt saw many interesting exhibits that day. They saw rocks formed when the earth was a new planet. They saw models of land and water animals that lived all over the world. They saw weapons and tools that humans had used for hundreds of years. All the time they were getting closer to the dinosaur exhibit and Sammy could see the entrance just ahead. He was really worried that Matt would walk right past it.

Sammy stopped Matt and explained that the dinosaurs were his favorite thing to see at the museum. He told Matt about the new T Rex exhibit. As he talked about the exhibit, Sammy got more and more excited. Matt could see how important it was to Sammy to see the dinosaurs. He wanted to be a good friend. Sammy knew a lot about dinosaurs and he taught Matt all kinds of interesting facts about them. When Sammy and Matt left the museum that day they were even better friends.

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Questions for Sammy and Matt

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Sammy excited to see at the museum?

2. Why was Sammy worried when he found out that Matt was his buddy?

3. What was the first thing Sammy saw when he entered the museum?

4. Why did Sammy follow Matt when Matt walked away from the dinosaur exhibit?

5. What kinds of things did Sammy and Matt see in the museum?

6. Why was Sammy worried that Matt would walk right past the entrance to the dinosaur exhibit?

7. Why did Sammy stop Matt from walking past the exhibit?

8. How could Matt tell that Sammy really wanted to see the dinosaurs?

9. What did Sammy do to help make Matt more interested in seeing the dinosaurs?

10. Why did Sammy and Matt become even better friends after their day at the museum?

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Sasha

All of Sasha's friends were reading a book about mysterious UFO's in the desert and she wanted to read it too. When Sasha asked her parents to buy her the book, they said she would have to pay for it herself. The book cost ten dollars and she didn't have enough money. She asked her parents if she could earn money by doing chores. They were happy to pay her for doing chores.

First Sasha's parents asked her to wash and dry the breakfast dishes. When she finished that, Sasha's mom asked her to help dust and vacuum. Sasha never realized how big their house was until she had to dust every room! Then Sasha's dad asked her to help rake the leaves in the yard. Sasha and her family were lucky to have a large yard with many trees. At least Sasha always thought they were lucky until she saw how many leaves were on the ground from all those trees.

When they finished raking Sasha was exhausted but her parents asked her if she could do one more thing. Sasha barely had enough energy to nod her head but she really wanted that book so she agreed. They all got in the car and Sasha wondered what the last chore could be.

As they parked near the local bookstore, Sasha's parents told her how proud they were of the hard work she had done that day. They gave her twenty dollars and told her she could spend it however she liked. Sasha was thrilled. She had enough money for the UFO mystery and something else. As she walked through the store, she could feel her energy returning.

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Questions for Sasha

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Sasha want money for?

2. How can you tell that Sasha really wanted to read that book?

3. What were some of the chores Sasha's parents asked her to help with?

4. Why was Sasha surprised at how big her house and yard were?

5. How did Sasha feel when she finally finished her chores?

6. Even though she was exhausted, Sasha agreed to do one more thing for her parents. One reason was because she really wanted the book. What would be another reason?

7. Where did Sasha's parents take her?

8. How do you think Sasha felt when her parents told her they were proud of her hard work?

9. Did Sasha's parents give her enough money to buy the UFO book?

10. Why do you think Sasha could feel her energy returning as she walked through the bookstore?

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Scott

Scott was lost in the forest. He was slightly nervous but refusing to panic. He was pretty sure that he could get himself out of this mess. After all, just last month he had written a report for school on how to find your way out of a forest. He knew the most important thing was to stay calm.

Scott sat down on a big rock and looked around. All he could see were tall trees and blue sky. At least he didn't have to worry about bad weather. He listened carefully too. Very faintly, he thought he could hear voices so he knew he wasn't too far from his group. Unfortunately, as he listened, the voices got fainter and he realized he would have to get going soon in order to catch up.

Scott knew better than to start walking without a plan, so he carefully looked all around. Nearby he could see what looked like a path. That must be the path they were all on before he wandered away, he realized. Excited about finding the path, he left the rock and walked toward it but when he got there he couldn't remember which direction they had been walking.

Telling himself to take a deep breath and relax, Scott thought hard for a moment. He looked both ways along the path but all he saw were trees and more trees. No clues there. Then he remembered that he'd been slightly out of breath and had walked over to that rock to sit for a minute. Feeling confident about his choice, Scott headed up the path in the direction where he thought he'd find his friends. Five minutes later, he had caught up with them and was laughing about his adventure.

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Questions for Scott

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Where was Scott lost?

2. How did Scott know he didn't have to worry about bad weather?

3. What else did he do besides look around?

4. How did he know that he had to get moving soon?

5. Why did Scott think it was important to have a plan before he started walking?

6. What did Scott see nearby that would help him find his way to the group?

7. Scott was excited to see the path but it didn't help him right away. Why not?

8. How did Scott decide which way to go on the path?

9. How long did it take for Scott to catch up with his friends?

10. Why did staying calm help Scott?

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Sophie

Sophie was really nervous. All the fifth graders in her school were required to do a dance unit as part of their gym class and she was a terrible dancer. Her friends had tried to teach her but she just didn't get it. The last thing she wanted to do was dance in front of all her classmates.

Sophie asked her parents if they would write a note to excuse her from gym. They were surprised because Sophie generally loved gym class. She explained to them that she was likely to make a fool of herself in front of her class and probably the whole school if she had to dance. Her parents smiled but told her that they couldn't excuse her from gym. They reminded her that she learned new things all the time at school and this would just be one more thing. They told her that being brave and doing something uncomfortable would make her stronger.

Sophie didn't want to be brave, she wanted to get out of the dance unit. She went to her gym teacher, Ms. Robb. Sophie was sure that Ms. Robb would excuse her when she explained how nervous she was. Disappointingly, Ms. Robb said almost the same thing her parents had said. Plus, she told Sophie that this was a dance that no one knew because she had made it up herself. Everyone would be learning it together. Sophie knew she was stuck.

The first day of the dance unit finally arrived and Ms. Robb explained the dance steps to the whole class. There was much groaning as everyone realized they would have to learn something new. The groans soon turned to laughter however, when the music began and everyone started bumping into each other. Sophie laughed along with her classmates. She realized that her parents and Ms. Robb were right about trying new things.

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Questions for Sophie

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Sophie nervous about?

2. Why did Sophie think that she would look foolish not just in front of her class but possibly in front of the whole school?

3. What did Sophie ask her parents to do?

4. Why did her parents smile when they told her they wouldn't give her the note?

5. What did Sophie do next to try to get out of the dance unit?

6. Why did Sophie feel stuck?

7. Why did the entire class groan when Ms. Robb explained the dance to them?

8. Why did everyone start laughing when the music started?

9. Why else might the class have been laughing when they started bumping into each other?

10. What lesson did Sophie learn?

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Thomas

Thomas knew he was in big trouble. He just wasn't sure who was going to be angrier with him - his parents or his brother Eddie. Either way, Thomas was not looking forward to going home. How was it possible that just a couple of hours ago he'd been the coolest kid at the park?

It all started on the way home from school. Thomas' brother Eddie had gotten a new bike and all of Thomas' friends wanted to see it. It was a special bike for riding off-road. Thomas knew that his brother had band practice after school and wouldn't be home. He told his friends to meet him at the park and said he'd "borrow" the bike. He hesitated for a moment as he grabbed the bike, but the urge to impress his friends was too strong.

Thomas' friends loved Eddie's new bike but soon they got bored with just looking at it and started playing soccer. Thomas laid the bike carefully on the ground where he could see it and joined the game. When Thomas realized it was time to go home, the bike was gone!

Thomas and his friends looked everywhere but couldn't find it. What was he going to tell Eddie and his parents? As Thomas trudged home, he saw his parents and brother waiting for him. Amazingly, Eddie's bike was there too! On his way home from band practice, Eddie had seen his bike in the park and decided to teach Thomas a lesson. He grabbed the bike without anyone seeing him. He knew that Thomas would panic. Thomas was incredibly relieved that the bike was safe and promised that he would never again take it without permission. To make sure that he wouldn't forget that promise, Thomas' parents grounded him for one month and gave him Eddie's chores for two months.

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Questions for Thomas

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Thomas' brother named?

2. What did Eddie have that Thomas wanted to show off to his friends?

3. Why did Thomas take the bike without permission?

4. Why did Thomas hesitate for a moment before taking the bike?

5. Why did Thomas' friends start playing soccer?

6. Even though Thomas puts the bike where he could see it, was it a good idea for him to join the soccer game?

7. What happened when Thomas realized it was time to go home?

8. Does it seem like Thomas rushed home?

9. What did Eddie do to teach Thomas a lesson?

10. Why would grounding Thomas and giving him Eddie's chores help him remember his promise never to take the bike again?

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Toby

There was a dinosaur in the backyard! Right now it was munching away on the tree tops, quite contentedly. But who knew what it might do next? Toby and his brother watched nervously from their bedroom window while the dinosaur chewed the top off their apple tree.

Toby had not expected this to happen when he told his neighbor that he really wished he could see a dinosaur up close. The neighbor claimed to have special powers that let wishes come true. The other kids in the neighborhood just thought he was a funny old man who made the best cookies on the block. The parents knew him as Bill but the kids all called him Cookie. Almost everyone thought Cookie was kidding about his special powers. But Toby thought, what could it hurt to tell Cookie about his wish to see a real dinosaur?

When he woke up the next morning, there it was. A very large Triceratops in the backyard. He quickly woke his brother up to look too, just in case he was imagining it. Judging by his brother's startled cry, Toby had definitely not imagined it. By this point, the dinosaur had mostly finished the apple tree and was using the tree's trunk as a toothpick. And by the way it was looking around, it didn't look like it was full, either. Just then the dinosaur noticed Toby and his brother in the window. It seemed to get a glint in its eyes. It started to make its way toward the house and Toby and his brother backed slowly away from the window...

Jack shut down his computer, feeling good about the start to his creative writing project. Even though he was tired, thoughts of Toby's upcoming adventures made sleep impossible.

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Questions for Toby

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Toby see in his backyard?

2. Why were Toby and his brother nervous about finding a dinosaur in the backyard?

3. Who did Toby tell about his wish to see a dinosaur up close?

4. Why did the kids call the old man Cookie?

5. Why did Toby tell Cookie that he wanted to see a dinosaur?

6. Why did Toby tell Cookie his wish even though everyone else thought he was kidding about his special powers?

7. What kind of tree did the dinosaur eat?

8. Why didn't the boys think that the apple tree was enough to satisfy the dinosaur?

9. Who is telling the story about Toby?

10. Why couldn't Jack sleep that night?

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Tom

Tom desperately wanted the new video game that was being advertised everywhere. His parents said he'd have to pay for it himself. The problem was, Tom didn't have any money.

Tom considered his options. He was already being paid for the chores he did around the house. His parents said he wasn't old enough to babysit. He was definitely too young to work in a store or gas station. As he sat in his house and wondered what he could do to earn money, he realized he could hear a couple of different dogs barking. He wondered if he could get paid for walking those dogs during the day while their owners were at work.

Tom talked to his parents and they thought it was a great idea. Tom thoughtfully made flyers that described how responsible and reliable he was. He went around his neighborhood and dropped them off wherever he knew a dog lived. By the end of that week, Tom had three clients. Every day after school Tom took each of the dogs for a walk. The dogs were delighted to get a walk in the afternoon and their owners were thrilled to have someone as responsible and reliable as Tom to walk their dogs. It went really well until the day that Tom decided to take all the dogs for a walk at one time.

Tom thought all three dogs would get along, and they did. They loved each other. So much so, that Tom had a hard time controlling them. The dogs wanted to play and race with each other. Before long, Tom was exhausted and their leashes were completely tangled. It took a long time to get the dogs untangled and settled down. From then on, Tom walked one dog at a time.

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Questions for Tom

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Why did Tom want money?

2. Why might Tom's parents say that he had to pay for it himself?

3. What jobs was Tom too young for?

4. What made Tom think of dog-walking as a possible job?

5. Why was it important that Tom describe himself as "responsible and reliable"?

6. How many clients did Tom get that first week?

7. Why was Tom's dog-walking business such a success?

8. What are some reasons why Tom might have wanted to take all the dogs for a walk at once?

9. What happened when Tom took all three dogs out together?

10. Why did Tom decide to go back to walking them one at a time?

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